

[YCC] Petition: Reverse Yale's Cuts to Summer Experience Funding (ISA/SEA) DRAFT

Petition Statement

On November 12, 2025, Dean Lewis announced [major cuts and programmatic restrictions](#) to the [International Study Award \(ISA\)](#) and [Summer Experience Award \(SEA\)](#), which enable students on financial aid to pursue study abroad, internships, research, and other essential opportunities during the summer.

We, the undersigned members of the Yale student body, denounce this decision.

President McInnis and other administrators have [repeatedly reaffirmed Yale's commitment](#) to [protecting financial aid](#); ISA & SEA have long been among the most important extensions of student financial support for students, and the cuts to these programs will inflict significant, tangible, and lasting damage on student opportunities for Yalies. As a result, these cuts directly contradict [Yale's mission commitment](#) to facilitate fully engaged access to the Yale experience for all students.

While we acknowledge the exigent budgetary pressure placed on Yale by the endowment tax, we firmly reject the premise that the necessary fiscal relief must come from denying current and future Yalies on financial aid their full Yale experience.

In practice, ISA & SEA have been some of Yale's most effective and constructive opportunity equalizers, giving students of all financial backgrounds chances to develop both through study abroad and professional experiences. Moving forward, however, the ISA & SEA cuts will force an ultimatum on the [roughly 1,000](#) Yalies who participate in the programs each year. By forcing this choice, Yale now imposes critical personal and career development sacrifices almost exclusively on Yale's most financially vulnerable students. According to Yale's Office of Fellowships, [75-80% of all ISA awards](#), for example, were granted to students on [80-100% of financial need](#). We refuse to endorse the idea that it is a pressing budgetary necessity to defund summer opportunities for the students who need it most.

On a per-dollar basis, the cuts to ISA & SEA will be among the most harmful cuts to student development of any possible cut at the undergraduate level. It has only been through the financial support of both the ISA & SEA that [15.5% of all Yalies](#) are able to become global scholars, lead in professional environments, and gain invaluable life skills each year. The cuts and programmatic restrictions to the ISA & SEA programs hinder students' abilities to gain the global experience and professional preparation needed to lead in their future fields and industries. Namely, the new [Student Experience Grant \(SEG\)](#) will only apply to Yale-affiliated study abroad programs, which will only intensify the stakes of already competitive programs by bottlenecking options and excluding students from these programs. Inevitably, Yale's decision will only continue to exacerbate [disparities in opportunity](#) in the Yale experience.

Altogether, we denounce the complete opacity surrounding the decision. The decision to cut ISA & SEA funding is objectionable because students were not given any opportunity to [provide feedback](#) or [input](#) in the decision making process. The lack of clarity about which resources Yale intends or does not intend to defund has created unnecessary uncertainty for students planning their academic and professional futures. Coupled with the ill-timed, late-semester announcement, these cuts now force many students to [reconsider carefully made plans](#) or risk jeopardizing valuable opportunities for future summers.

If Yale seeks to honestly "[be the university that best prepares students for global citizenship and leadership](#)" — if it seeks to help students "[take maximum advantage of](#)" professional development opportunities — and if it seeks to live up to [the pride it claims](#) in its financial support for summer opportunities, it must reverse its cuts to ISA & SEA.

Accordingly, we, the undersigned members of the Yale study body, call on Yale to reverse its current cuts to ISA & SEA. We call on Yale to meaningfully and earnestly collaborate with students through a student-administration working group to develop an implementable solution for restoring summer experience funding. And we call on Yale to make its budgeting priorities eminently clear to students by implementing a solution that protects Yale's most financially vulnerable students.

Respectfully,

The Undersigned Members of the Yale Student Body

Alex William Chen, YCC Speaker of the Senate

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If you would like to provide personal testimony or further thoughts on Yale's changes to the ISA & SEA, please do so

below: